7

"Some Reflections upon Inspiration"

EDWARD J. YOUNG

Thy Word Is Truth

Previously published as "Some Reflections upon Inspiration," in *Thy Word Is Truth: Some Thoughts on the Biblical Doctrine of Inspiration* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1957), 83–109. Reprinted by permission of the publisher. All rights reserved.

". . . The Scriptures are perfect, inasmuch as they were uttered by the Word of God and His Spirit, though we want the knowledge of their mysteries."

Irenaeus

". . . the words of the prophets are the words of God."

Theophilus Of Antioch

". . . the records of the gospels are oracles of the Lord, pure oracles as silver purified seven times in the fire."

Origen

In what has been written thus far, we have tried to set forth clearly and simply what the Bible itself has to say about its inspiration. There can be little serious disagreement over whether the Bible actually does teach verbal inspiration. The doctrine expounded in the preceding pages is nothing more than a digest of what Scripture itself teaches. Objection to the doctrine, therefore, is in reality objection to the Scriptures. This is not surprising, since men today do not wish to be guided by the Scriptures in their thinking. They may agree, and they probably will, that we have correctly expounded the scriptural doctrine, but they protest against that doctrine.

Many are the objections which they raise, and it becomes necessary at this point to face some of them. Such a procedure will by no means be without profit, for not only will it enable us to give an answer to many of the current criticisms of the scriptural doctrine of inspiration, but it will also enable us to understand that doctrine more clearly. To these objections, then, let us direct our thought.

One of the best ways to attack something is to demonstrate that it is unimportant, and that is precisely what some writers attempt to accomplish with respect to the biblical doctrine of verbal inspiration. The originals of Scripture are lost, so it is argued, and we cannot completely reconstruct them. Therefore, these originals must have been unimportant. Evidently God did not think that it was necessary for us to have them. If a man wishes to do scholarly work on the Bible, he must use the Greek and the Hebrew texts which are available to him. He cannot obtain the original and must be content with the texts at hand. More than that, the plain man who turns to the Bible for his devotional study must be content with a Bible in his own vernacular. He is removed from the original even a step further. Consequently, all this talk about an inspired and errorless original text is really beside the point. Furthermore, even if there were errors in the original, this would not hinder us from receiving a blessing from the Bible; and we would be foolish indeed if we were to maintain that, unless the original were free of error, we could receive no blessing from the Bible.

But is the doctrine of an errorless autographa of Scripture actually so unimportant after all? A little reflection, we think, will make it clear that such is not at all the case. Let us suppose that the Scriptures actually were given to us by a special revelation of God. In making this supposition we realize full well that we are going counter to the main stream of current thought. Grant, however that such is the case. If the Scriptures are indeed breathed forth from the mouth of God, does it matter whether they contain in them statements which are contrary to fact? To ask the question in this fashion is, of course, to answer it. It matters tremendously, for the veracity of God himself is at stake.

How disturbing is the annoyance of tiny inaccuracies! Upon receiving a letter filled with trifling errors and misspelled words, we are displeased and annoyed; the letter casts reflection upon its writer. In fact, to send such a letter is to do a most discourteous thing. In writing a letter we want to spell our words correctly; also, for the sake of our own reputation, if for nothing else, we want to get our facts straight. If a person does not even take the trouble to do this he may justly be considered a boor or an ignoramus. It

is difficult to maintain a high respect for someone who, in writing letters to us, is consistently careless. We do, of course, receive letters from people who are poorly educated, and their errors, even though regrettable, we are willing to pardon. When, however, an educated person writes, and permits minor inaccuracies to characterize his writing, we are disappointed in him, and our respect for him is affected by it.

God has revealed to us his Word. What are we to think of him if this Word is glutted with little annoying inaccuracies? Why could not the omnipotent and omniscient God have taken the trouble to give us a Word that was free from error? Was it not a somewhat discourteous thing for him to have breathed forth from his mouth a message filled with mistakes? Of course, it was discourteous; it was downright rude and insulting. The present writer finds it difficult to have much respect for such a God. Does he expect us to worship him? What kind of a God is he if he has given such an untrustworthy Word to mankind? And this brings us to the heart of the matter. The Scriptures claim to be breathed forth from his mouth; if they partake of error, must not he himself also partake thereof?

He, of course, tells us that his Word is pure. If there are mistakes in that Word, however, we know better; it is not pure. He tells us that his judgments are righteous, but we know better; as a matter of fact, his judgments are mixed with error. He declares that his law is the truth. His law contains the truth, let us grant him that, but we know that it contains error. If the autographa of Scripture are marred by flecks of mistake, God simply has not told us the truth concerning his Word. To assume that he could breathe forth a Word that contained mistakes is to say, in effect, that God himself can make mistakes. We must maintain that the original of Scripture is infallible for the simple reason that it came to us directly from God himself.

It does not follow from this that only an errorless text can be of devotional benefit to Christians, nor do those who believe in the inerrancy of Scripture maintain such a position. Thousands have been brought to a knowledge of the truth and have come to know him whom to know aright is life eternal, and they have had no inerrant text. When one reads some of the arguments that have been raised in opposition to the doctrine of inspiration, one very often receives the impression that there is a good bit of tilting at windmills. Of course an inerrant text is not necessary for the devotional life. There are those who through the King James Version have come to know Christ and have grown in grace daily, yet the King James Version is not inerrant.

Be this as it may, however, the serious student of the Bible will desire

to approximate the original insofar as that is possible. We may revert to the illustration of the teacher who had received a letter from the president. When the original was destroyed (shall we say that it is unimportant whether the president of the United States made minor mistakes in his letter?), the teacher had only the copies which the pupils had made. As a result of the ignorance of the children who did the copying, these became imperfect copies. The teacher might have remained satisfied with these imperfect copies. She, however, had great respect for her president. Consequently, she endeavored to the best of her ability to correct each copy so that the exact wording of the original might be restored.

It would be foolish to maintain that because they contained mistakes, the copies were therefore without any value. Anyone could read those copies and learn what the president had written. To obtain the president's message, all one had to do was to read a copy of his letter. So it is with the Bible. The copies of Scripture which are now extant are remarkably accurate, and hence, like the original, they are "profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness" (2 Tim. 3:16). Minor, indeed, are those errors which may be found in the copies of the Bible which we possess, and through careful, scholarly study they are being in remarkable measure removed. Very different, however, was the original. That was the actual God-breathed Word, true to fact in all its statements. Let no one say that it is a matter of indifference whether this original was inerrant; it is a matter of greatest importance, for the honor and veracity of God himself are at stake. If there are actual errors in the original copies of the Bible, the Word which has come forth from the mouth of God is not a perfect Word, and the God of truth is guilty of error. If God has spoken falsely in his Word, he is not the God of truth, and consequently, the Christian religion is a false religion. This conclusion cannot be evaded. It is for this reason that those who embrace the biblical doctrine are so zealous to maintain the absolute perfection of the divine revelation in its original manuscripts.

It should be made clear, however, that if there actually are errors in the original manuscripts, we have no means of knowing where those errors start and where they stop. If God has erred in his speech at one point, how do we know that he has not done so at others? If he has denied the truth once, he might have done it more than once. If in minor matters he has given us falsehood, how do we know that in weightier things—since he is the Author of his Word—he has not done the same thing? This conclusion cannot be avoided. Men may talk all they wish about the unimportance

and irrelevance of minor errors in chronology and history; the real truth of the matter is that if God has blundered so badly on those matters in which we can check him, how do we know that he has not also blundered just as badly in speaking to us of himself? It is not an unimportant point. If the original manuscripts of Scripture contain mistakes of fact and statements which are contrary to the truth, then we cannot escape the conclusion that these original manuscripts, since they are inscribed with the outbreathed Word of God, are not trustworthy. If God has lied to us at one point, by what conceivable standard may we say that he has not lied to us at others? If the truth in what are sometimes called "minor matters" is of no importance to him, how do we know that he has any regard for the truth in so-called major concerns? In fact, if he has violated the truth even in these small things, how do we know that he has any concern for the truth at all? If he is the God of truth, he has certainly taken a strange way of showing it. The so-called errors of the extant copies of Scripture, therefore, matters of chronology and the like, must be attributed to those human beings who made copies of the Bible. They are not from the God of Truth himself.

Amazing indeed is the cavalier manner in which modern theologians relegate this doctrine of an inerrant original Scripture to the limbo of the unimportant. Discovering that it is possible for men to be blessed of God without an errorless text, men rush to the conclusion that therefore an infallible Bible is unnecessary and unimportant. So dogmatic are they in this procedure, so confident are their assertions that the doctrine of an inerrant Scripture is unimportant, that they seem not to realize what they are doing. It is obvious, we are sometimes told, that the great doctrines of the Christian faith can be formulated from the copies of the Bible which are now in our possession. The church never had an infallible copy of the Bible with which to work. Consequently, it is asked, why should we bother with such a doctrine? We do not have the original copies of Scripture. How can we know what they were like? We can say nothing about them. Hence, the modern theologian is very eager to maintain his silence concerning them or, if he does not maintain it, to declare that even in the original copies of Scripture there were errors. He seems to be sure that the originals of Scripture were not infallible.

There is, of course, one means that is very widely adopted in order to escape from the difficulty of maintaining an originally inerrant Bible. It consists simply in equating the revelation of God with his ordinary providential working. In God's providence there have arisen, for example, those writings, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, which we know as the works

of Homer. Without entering into the question how much Homer actually had to do with their composition, other than to remark that we believe that they display the marks of one great mind, we may say that in a certain sense, these works were given to us from God. Who can read the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* without being greatly impressed by their magnificence? Surely the genius which went into their composition was a gift from none other than God himself. Homer—assuming that he was the author—was a highly gifted and endowed man, and we may thank God for the talent that was given to him. At the same time, we would not say that the very words of either the *Iliad* or the *Odyssey* were taught to the poet by God. We certainly would not maintain that he, as he wrote, was borne by the Holy Spirit. Nor would we feel for an instant that, if there were serious errors in the original copies of the *Iliad* and *Odyssey*, such mistakes were a reflection upon God himself. Rather, we do not particularly care whether there were errors in the originals of Homer. Whoever wrote those originals made the errors, and it is not too important who that author was. The originals were not given to the poet by a direct, special revelation. It is in similar fashion that some would also treat the Bible. They would regard its composition as a mere act of God's providence, and would in effect deny any special revelation. The composition of the Bible, therefore, on this view, would not differ in any essential respect from that of the great poetry of ancient Greece.

If this conception of the origin of the Bible be correct, it of course follows that the Bible is in reality no different from any other book. The men who wrote the Bible may indeed have been serious-minded men; they were not, however, borne by the Spirit of God as they wrote, nor were the words which they penned God-breathed. They were men of their own time, subject to the ignorance and limitations of their time.

Serious-minded these authors may have been; that they were good men, however, is open to question. The words which they wrote were given to the world as words which the writers received by direct revelation from God. If, in a matter so fundamental as that of the origin of their words, the writers of Scripture did not tell the truth, how can we even say that they were good men. They were not good men, but deceivers. If the Bible arose as other books arise, merely in the ordinary providence of God, the Bible is not a good book, for the Bible *claims* to be a special revelation of God.

These are the implications that one cannot escape if he is to accept the Bible as being no different in respect to its origin from other books. Those

who thus treat the Bible say not a word that would lead one to believe that they themselves seriously consider the words of the Scriptures to be God-breathed. They do not come to grips with the question whether the original of the Bible was breathed forth from the mouth of God himself. If the Bible came to us in the ordinary way through God's providential working—if, in other words, the Bible came to us just as other books do—then, it goes without saying, that it matters not one whit whether the originals of the Bible were free from error. If, on the other hand, (foreign and uncongenial as the thought is to the mind of the modern theologian) the Bible was given to man by special revelation of the one living and true God, it makes all the difference in the world whether the Bible came to us free from error. If the Bible is indeed the Word of God, is that Word free from error, or is God bound by the limitations and errors that adhere to sinful humanity? There is the issue, and it cannot be evaded.

If we are going to reject the Bible as God's special revelation, that is one thing. If, however, we are going to cleave to the doctrine of inspiration, let us face the claims of the Bible honestly. The Bible asserts that it is the very Word of God. If we believe that assertion, let us accept it and follow its implications where they lead. It would be a great boon to the entire religious situation if those who no longer believe in the scriptural doctrine of inspiration would cease speaking and writing as though they did so believe. When a man says that he considers the Bible to be the Word of God, the humble Christian will likely take his words at face value and think that he intends them in the same sense as does the Bible itself. Such, of course, is not the case at all. Merely for the sake of simple honesty, it would be a great advantage if in the present religious situation men would make it clear what they mean by their usage of scriptural terminology.

If, however, we do accept the teaching of the Bible, God grant that we may not be ashamed of that teaching! The Bible, in manifold ways, has proclaimed and asserted its divinity. It has emphatically declared that in a unique manner it has come to us from God. If, in professing to believe the Bible, we are going to be serious, let us accept its claims and not try to explain them away! Let us follow our God, who cannot lie; and since he cannot lie, let us believe that his Word is truth itself. Those copies of Scripture which came forth from God Almighty were infallible and inerrant. No matter what men may say to the contrary, no matter how much they may seek to obscure the issue, in the very nature of the case it could not have been otherwise.

An Objection

At this point it may be well to consider briefly an objection which is sometimes raised. Since, as we have maintained, God cannot err, the Word which comes forth from his mouth must also itself be inerrant. This conclusion, it is said by way of objection, need not at all follow. We might as well argue that, since Christ is the perfect Son of God, therefore he could not die. As a matter of fact, however, he did die. And because the sinless Son of God did die, we cannot maintain that the Holy Ghost could not have condescended to use the poverty, error, and sin of the biblical writers whom he employed. To this objection several things need to be said. Basically, however, it appears to confuse sin and the consequences of sin. All that God speaks, because God is Truth itself, must also be true and in accordance with fact. To maintain that God may have uttered words that are false or that do not square with the facts is in effect to make of God a liar. What, however, shall we say about the death of Christ? Jesus Christ, according to the Bible, is God become man. When the second person of the ever-blessed Trinity took to himself our human nature, he took that nature apart from sin. Hence the importance of the doctrine of the virgin birth. That holy Babe which was born of Mary was the Son of God. Although he became flesh and dwelled among us, although he became man in the truest sense of the word, he nevertheless became a sinless man. Holy, harmless, and undefiled, he lived his blessed life upon this earth in our midst. Why, then, did he die? Does not death come only upon those who have sinned? But he was not a transgressor of the law. Why then did he die? The answer is that the guilt of our sin was laid to his account, and as our substitute he bore the penalty of our sin. He was, in other words, punished in our stead. It was our sin for which he was smitten. How wondrously the prophet has set it forth: "He *was* wounded for our transgressions, he *was* bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace *was* upon him; and with his stripes we are healed" (Isa. 53:5). What Isaiah says is the same thing that the apostle sets forth so beautifully in his second epistle to the Corinthians (5:21): "For he hath made him *to be* sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him." If Christ had taken unto himself a sinful nature, and so had died as a consequence of his own sins, then, indeed, there might be force in the objection which we are now considering. Such, however, was not the case. Not for his own sins did he die, but for the sins of others.

> What thou, dear Lord, hast suffered
> Was all for sinners' gain;
> Mine, mine was the transgression,
> But thine the deadly pain.

In those words we find the correct statement of the case. The transgression was not his but that of his people; the deadly pain, however, fell upon him, for in their stead he was punished.

If he were a sinner, then, indeed, we should expect him to die. Sin brings forth death, and sin also issues in error and fallibility. To say that God has erred is to say that he has sinned; to assert, however, that Christ died is not necessarily to say that he has died for his own sin. The death of Christ in no way implies that he himself was a sinful man, and hence an appeal to the death of our Lord, such as we have just considered, in no wise militates against the biblical doctrine of inerrancy.

A New View

Is not, it may be asked, this doctrine of an inerrant original text comparatively new? Was it not developed during the last century by orthodox Protestant theologians? Luther and Calvin, it is often claimed, did not hold anything similar to it. More than that, the Fathers of the church certainly did not teach it. Therefore, the conclusion seems to be, the doctrine is one which belongs not to catholic Christianity but only to a small segment of the church.

Modern writers like to cast their scorn upon this view and to declare how recent it is. Of course, it might as well be noted in passing, a doctrine is not necessarily false because its implications were only recently realized. The church existed for many centuries before Luther saw the force of the scriptural doctrine of justification by faith. Despite that fact, however, men have always been justified by faith. The doctrine was true long before Luther saw its force and implications. If, therefore, it should be true that only in recent years men have begun to see the implications of the doctrine of inspiration, that in itself is no condemnation.

Is this doctrine, however, something which has just been developed during the last century? Our answer is, as we have been seeking to show, that it is found in the pages of the Scriptures themselves. It is perfectly true that its full implications were not set forth before the Reformation. During the sixteenth and the seventeenth centuries men who deeply loved the Lord Jesus Christ and his church worked out some of the implications of the scriptural teaching on inspiration. They did this, not because they had a bent of mind inclined toward philosophical speculation and sophistical

niceties and wished to give satisfaction thereto, but because they faced a powerful foe, a foe which would deny to the Bible its position of supreme and final authority and would substitute therefore the church. That foe was Rome, and the issue which was raised was vital, and one which struck at the very roots of the Christian religion. To which ultimate authority is the humble and devout believer to listen? Is he to listen to what the church has to say? Is the church to tell him what he is to believe and how he is to live? To these questions Rome said yes, and its reply was fortified and buttressed by strong and powerful arguments. To listen to the church, however, would be a return to the fiction of a merit religion such as had characterized the Middle Ages and would close the door upon the gospel of the free grace of a merciful God and lead the soul into that bondage against which the great Reformers, Luther and Calvin, had so valiantly struggled.

There were those however, who refused to take the retrograde step into the darkness and superstition of the Middle Ages. To listen to the church, they believed, would be to shut one's ears to the voice of God. It must be shown that the church was usurping a place which did not belong to her, a place which was God's alone. Was this blessed Book, this Book which had led Luther out of the dark night of sacerdotalism and priestcraft into the glorious light of the grace of God, a Book whose claims could be trusted? The Book itself asserted, and that in no uncertain manner, that it was the Word of God. In what sense, however, was it the Word of God? Was it merely a secondary authority to be used as a support for whatever the church thought men should believe? That was the way in which, in effect, it was regarded by Rome. Or was it the Word of God in a different sense? Was it the final court of appeal to which men must harken if they would be saved?

At this crucial period there were not wanting men whose hearts God had touched, who knew that Christ had died for them, who loved the Savior because he had delivered them from their sins, and these men could not sit by and watch the Bible be relegated to a secondary position. They were desirous that the Bible should receive its full recognition. Hence, they made earnest and careful study of the Bible in order to discover what it had to say for itself. As a result the church has been enriched by their writings. We have, for example, the magnificent treatise on the Scriptures which Francis Turretin has left. There are those who could condemn that treatise and others of a similar nature by labelling them with the word "scholasticism." However, he who will take the trouble to work through what Turretin has written will make the discovery that here was a heart

aflame with devotion to the Christ who had died for him and seeking only to be true to what God had revealed concerning his Holy Word.

It is certainly true that during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries the implications of the doctrine of biblical inspiration were worked out more fully than before. And we may humbly give thanks to God that he gave men of such devotion to his church. We could do far worse today than to study these great masters of Protestant theology.

This does not mean that we must agree with everything that they wrote. We must, rather, test what they wrote to see whether it actually is taught in the Bible. No doubt there are references and allusions in the writings of the Protestant scholastics which are not particularly relevant today. No doubt there may have been a tendency on the part of some to a certain formalism in statement, and possibly also to over-refinement in argument. With all their faults, however, these men rendered a great service, and we may thank God that he saw fit to give them to his church.

It is also true that as a counter to the destructive criticism of the nineteenth century, a criticism which wrought such havoc in the church of Christ, even further thought was given to the doctrine of inspiration. We may thank God for men such as Charles Hodge, A. A. Hodge, and Benjamin B. Warfield. If students for the ministry would study the writings of these men instead of those of the present neoorthodox writers, the church would find itself in a far healthier condition.

The two following quotations will give the reader an inkling of the penetrating insight and fidelity to Scripture manifested by A. A. Hodge and B. B. Warfield:

> We believe that the great majority of those who object to the affirmation that Inspiration is verbal are impelled thereto by a feeling, more or less definite, that the phrase implies that Inspiration is, in its essence, a process of verbal dictation, or that, at least in some way, the revelation of the thought, or the inspiration of the writer, was by means of the control which God exercised over his words. And there is the more excuse for this misapprehension because of the extremely mechanical conceptions of Inspiration maintained by many former advocates of the use of this term "verbal." This view, however, we repudiate as earnestly as any of those who object to the language in question. At the present time the advocates of the strictest doctrine of Inspiration, in insisting that it is verbal, do not mean that, in any way, the thoughts were inspired by means of the words, but simply that the divine superintendence, which we call Inspiration, extended to the verbal expression of the

> thoughts of the sacred writers, as well to the thoughts themselves, and that, hence, the Bible considered as a record, an utterance in words of a divine revelation is the Word of God to us. Hence, in all the affirmations of Scripture of every kind, there is no more error in words of the original autographs than in the thoughts they were chosen to express. The thoughts and words are both alike human, and, therefore subject to human limitations, but the divine superintendence and guarantee extends to the one as much as to the other.[1]

What a matchless statement of inspiration is found in the following words:

> The Bible, moreover, being a work of the Spirit for spiritual ends, each writer was prepared precisely for his part in the work by the personal dealings of the Holy Spirit with his soul. Spiritual illumination is very different from either revelation or inspiration, and yet it had under the providence of God a large share in the genesis of Scripture, contributing to it a portion of that Divine element which makes it the Word of God. The Psalms are divinely inspired records of the religious experiences of the writers, and are by God himself authoritatively set forth as typical and exemplary for all men forever. Paul and John and Peter largely drew upon the resources, and followed the lines of their own personal religious experience in the intuitional or the logical development of their doctrine, and their experience had, of course, been previously divinely deemed for that very purpose. And in determining their religious experience, God so far forth determined their contributions to Scripture. And He furnished each of the Sacred writers, in addition to that which came to him through natural channels, all the knowledge needed for his appointed task, either by vision, suggestion, dictation or elevation of faculty, or otherwise, according to His will. The natural knowledge came from all sources, as traditions, documents, testimonies, personal observations and recollections; by means also of intuitions, logical processes of thought, feeling, experience, etc., and yet all were make under the general direction of God's providence. The supernatural knowledge became confluent with the natural in a manner which violated no law of reason or of freedom. And throughout the whole of His work the Holy Spirit was present, causing His energies to flow into the spontaneous exercises of the writer's faculties, elevating and directing where need be, and everywhere securing the errorless expression in language of the thought designed by God. This last element is what we call Inspiration.[2]

[1] "Inspiration," by A. A. Hodge and B. B. Warfield, in *The Presbyterian Review*, No. 6 (April 1881): 232–33.
[2] Ibid., 230–31.

Thank God for men who have been concerned to study the church's doctrines and to discover what are the implications of those doctrines! Would that our present day could boast of such painstaking Bible study as that which characterized the labors of the men just mentioned. Let us freely grant and rejoice in the fact that there has indeed been development in the understanding of this precious doctrine.

What, however, about the period before the Reformation? As we read over the history of the Christian church, there is one thing that impresses us, namely, the reverence in which the Holy Scriptures were held. Consider Justin Martyr as he appeals to the Scriptures to prove the deity of Jesus Christ. Why should he thus employ the Scriptures, were it not that he believed them to be the final court of appeal? Or hear Origen as, from the Bible, he endeavors to refute the specious attacks of a Celsus upon Christianity. Whatever errors Origen may have entertained, and he certainly had his share of them, the Scriptures, as his own practice makes clear, were to him the last and ultimate court of appeal. He may in effect have nullified this fact by the allegorizing with which he covered the Scriptures but, nevertheless, he at least thought that he was appealing to the Bible. Where they spoke, he was willing to listen; what they enjoined, he would put into practice. And it might be noted that the tremendous labor which he expended upon his sixfold version of the Bible, the Hexapla, is a tribute to his devotion to the Bible. More than that, however, the twenty-odd years in which he was engaged in this study, and particularly, his careful transcription of the Hebrew Old Testament in Greek characters, is, say what one will, a remarkable tribute to his belief in the verbal inspiration of the Bible.

This monumental work of Origen's was no mere antiquarian pursuit, wrought for the sake of scholarship as such. Origen was not interested primarily in scientific research. Rather, it was as a servant of Jesus Christ, a minister of the gospel, that he labored. By means of the Hexapla, he hoped that the church would have a better text of the Bible and, consequently, that the gospel might be more faithfully preached. From such deep devotion to the text of Scripture and its actual words, one receives the impression that Origen, were he alive today, would be one of the staunchest defenders of verbal inspiration.

Nor does Origen stand alone in his devotion to the Scriptures. One might find example after example of trust in the final authority of the Bible. The question is not what books of Scripture were regarded as inspired; there were indeed differences of opinion as to the extent of the canon. What is at issue is that throughout the course of church history,

men appealed to that which they regarded as Scripture. If they considered a book to be Scripture, then they knew that they were bound to that book as to the very Word of God.

Valiant is the stand which Luther took upon this question. Hear him as he asserts, "Arguments based upon reason determine nothing, but because the Holy Ghost says it is true, it is true."[3] Well known are his brave words, spoken at Worms:

> Unless I am convinced by testimony from Scripture or evident reason—for I believe neither the Pope nor the Councils alone, since it is established that they have often erred and contradicted themselves—I am conquered by the writings cited by me, and my conscience is captive to the Word of God; recant I will not, since it is neither safe nor honest to do ought against conscience.[4]

And again,

> I have learned to ascribe this honor [i.e., infallibility] only to books which are termed canonical, so that I confidently believe that not one of their authors erred, but the other authors, no matter how distinguished by great sanctity and teaching, I read in this way, that I do not regard them as true because they themselves judged in this wise but in so far as they could convince me through the authority of the canonical writings or other clear deductions.[5]

From the time of the apostles until the present, God's people have loved his Word. In times of sorrow, they have found solace in its promises; in days of sadness, they have been comforted and strengthened by its testimonies; in the midst of happiness, they have rejoiced in its commands, and always has this been so because they have regarded this Word as God's Word; its words, indeed, have been a blessing to their souls. Thus, even though many of its implications have only been worked out since the days of the Reformation, the idea of verbal inspiration has been present from the beginning. One thing at least is clear: the doctrine of verbal inspiration, which Bible believers are defending today, is a doctrine which has been defended since the days of the apostles. It is indeed the very view which the apostles and, above all, our Lord himself maintained. The views of modernism, neoorthodoxy, and destructive criticism do not represent a natural development

[3] M. Reu, *Luther and the Scriptures*, 1944, 16.
[4] Ibid., 28.
[5] Ibid., 24.

of the attitude toward the Bible which has characterized the church since the time of its inception. Those who espouse the doctrine of verbal inspiration and scriptural infallibility are in a true apostolic succession.

Is the Bible Infallible Only in Faith and Practice?

Another objection, however, lies ready to hand. In stressing the fact that the Scriptures in matters of historical and geographical detail are infallible, we are charged with going too far. The Bible, it is acknowledged, is of course the only infallible rule of faith and practice, but that is as far as its infallibility goes. There are those who are willing to subscribe to the statement that the Scriptures are the only infallible rule of faith and practice, and by that declaration they mean, if we may employ the language of Charles A. Briggs,

> they are infallible in all matters of divine revelation, in all things where men need infallible guidance from God. We do not thereby claim that a writer dwelling in Palestine had an infallible knowledge of countries he had never visited, of dates of events beyond his own experience where he had to rely upon tradition or doubtful or imperfect human records. We do not affirm that he gave an exact and infallible report of words spoken centuries before, which had never been previously recorded; or an infallible description of events that happened in distant lands and ages; removing from the traditional report every excess of color and every variation in detail. We do not thereby claim that the writer of the poem of the creation knew geology and astronomy, and natural history better than the experts of modern science, but teach us the science of God and redemption, and the art of having holy, godlike lives. The Bible is the only infallible rule of faith and practice.[6]

In the words of this quotation Briggs has stated, perhaps as well as anyone, the objection of those who think they can limit the infallibility of Scripture to faith and practice. The objection, however, does not get at the root of the matter. It is an objection that has a certain pious ring to it and appears to possess a certain amount of plausibility. Plausible as it is, however, it cannot stand. Several things must be remarked concerning it.

In the first place, it is an objection that does not understand the true nature of faith. We do not believe, say these objectors, that the Bible is infallible in anything but faith and practice. It is not infallible in philosophy;

[6] Charles Augustus Briggs, *The Bible, The Church and The Reason* (1892), 93–94.

it is not infallible in astronomy; it is not infallible in other sciences; it is infallible only when it tells us what we are to believe. When, however, we come to examine the question what we are to believe, we discover that the doctrines which Scripture commends are rooted and grounded upon that which was done in history. The Christian faith, as it is revealed in the Bible, is not a mass of abstractions divorced from history. It is not eternal truths and ideals but rather the account of something that God did for us upon this earth in history. Hence, it becomes very important to us to know whether what the Bible has to say about these historical matters is correct or not.

According to the Bible our salvation depends upon the death of Jesus Christ at Calvary and upon his subsequent resurrection from the dead. Now, it is quite important to know certain details about the tomb in which he was laid. Was that tomb empty upon the third day? Was there an actual historical resurrection or not? Questions such as these intrude themselves into our consideration and will not be pushed aside. Is the Bible, therefore, correct in what it has to say of these historical details or not? If the historical framework in which the great redemptive acts of God took place is a framework which is not to be trusted, how do we know that we have a true and correct account of those redemptive acts themselves?

History and faith cannot be divorced the one from the other. Remove its historical basis and faith vanishes. To understand our faith properly we must study history, and this history is offered to us in the Bible. To say that what the Bible relates of history is fallible, but what it relates of faith is infallible is to talk nonsense. Apart from history there is no faith. The separation between the two which some seek to make is impossible. The only faith that can legitimately bear the name Christian is one that is rooted in historical events. From these it cannot be separated.

This brings us to another consideration. Who is to say what is faith and what is not? Those who claim that the Bible is infallible only as a rule of faith do not define where faith begins and where it ends. This fact may be illustrated by an appeal to the first chapter of Genesis. With respect to this chapter, how far does the infallibility of the Bible extend? Is everything that is related in this important chapter necessarily in error? Or are some statements true and some false? What is infallible and what is not infallible? Where does "faith" end and historical details begin? What, in other words, are the precise limits of "faith" in this first chapter of Genesis? What are the matters of "faith" herein revealed concerning which we may say that the Bible is infallible? And more than that, we would ask, who is to tell us

what is and what is not a matter of faith? On these important questions the advocates of the view that the Bible is infallible only in matters of faith and practice are strangely silent. It will probably be acknowledged that in telling us that God is the Creator, the Bible is infallible. No doubt Dr. Briggs, from whom we have just made a rather lengthy quotation, would at least maintain such a position. Others, however, do not wish to join Dr. Briggs in this belief. They are indeed willing to employ the words of the first verse of Genesis and they are also willing to speak of God as the Creator. Their language, however, bears a different connotation from that of Dr. Briggs, for they also make it clear that they do not believe in creation in the sense intended by Genesis 1. Both Dr. Briggs and those who reject the first verse of Genesis would doubtless wish to be known as Christians. Dr. Briggs, we think, would say that the doctrine of creation as taught in the Bible is a necessary article of faith. Others, on the contrary, would say that as it is taught in the Bible, the doctrine is not necessary at all to faith. Not only is it not necessary, they would furthermore maintain, but it is even positively harmful. Who, then, is to settle the issue? Who is to tell us what is and what is not of faith? Dr. Briggs may have certain ideas as to what faith is; others however, have quite different ideas. When, therefore, it is declared that the Bible is an infallible rule of faith, we may be pardoned if we ask the simple question, What is this faith? It should be clear that those who assert that only in matters of faith and practice, as distinguished, for example, from historical statements, is the Bible infallible, are in fact erecting the human mind as the ultimate judge of what is and what is not faith. We are, of course, far from maintaining that the human writers of the Scriptures were of themselves infallible in all their knowledge. We are far from holding that Moses, to take an example, possessed advanced knowledge of modern science. If Moses had depended upon his own ideas of science, he would have produced an account of creation that would have been anything but infallible. In writing of creation, however, Moses did not depend upon his own ideas but wrote only that which was revealed to him by God.

Thus we come to the heart of the objection which we are now considering. Those who assert that only in matters of faith the Bible is infallible do not seem to appreciate the fact that the Bible is a revelation of God. In asserting that the Bible is infallible, we are not basing this infallibility upon the knowledge of the human writers of Scripture. It may be that Moses, Isaiah, John, and Paul were all men whose views of astronomy are today outmoded. Probably they held opinions on many other matters which would now be regarded as out of date. The Bible, however, is not

simply the work of Moses and Isaiah, John and Paul. If it were, what a jumble of confusion and error it would be! It might then be little better than the works of other great men of antiquity. The Bible, however, is the revelation of God. The information which it offers to us is information which was communicated to its human writers by God. The reason, therefore, why the first chapter of Genesis reads as though it were written only yesterday is that the information contained therein was revealed to Moses by God. Much as men today like to talk about the prescientific character of the Bible, there is no one who can prove the presence of an error in the first chapter of Genesis.

The Bible, it is often said, is not a textbook of astronomy. That we freely grant. The Bible nowhere claims to be such a textbook. It is, however, a textbook of the philosophy of astronomy; when the Bible speaks, as in Genesis 1, upon astronomical matters, it is absolutely in accord with fact in what it says. It may be that through misunderstanding and fallible interpretations of our own, we have obscured what the Bible has to say. When, however, the true meaning of the Scripture is obtained, we have the truth upon that particular subject about which the Scripture is speaking. The Bible is not a textbook of geography; when, however, it speaks upon a geographical matter, it speaks with absolute authority. The Bible is not a textbook of geology; when, however, it speaks upon matters of geology, it is infallible in what it says. Human theories of astronomy, geology, and geography have changed and do change. The Bible, in what it says upon these subjects, is not in any sense in disharmony with the facts. That it may disagree with certain theories is, of course, granted; it does not disagree with the facts, since those facts also were given of God. The Bible, we must conclude, is infallible in all that it says, or we cannot be sure that it is infallible in anything. We cannot with any consistency maintain that only in the realm of faith and practice is it without error.

Do Protestants Misuse the Bible?

One frequently hears the assertion these days that Luther set Christendom free from the Roman pope, and now the time has arrived for someone to set Christendom free from the paper pope. Until the time of the Reformation, it is maintained, the church was considered infallible; now, however, the Bible has taken its place. The Bible is given the position of authority which once was occupied by the church. In rejecting an infallible church Protestantism has simply substituted an infallible book. This is bad, we are

told, because the Bible does not claim such a place for itself. There is only one who should have supreme authority, namely, Jesus Christ. Protestants have put the Bible in the place of Jesus Christ, and that is one of the great weaknesses of Protestantism.

Plausible words are these; plausible, but utterly false. Before a little sober reflection they lose their force entirely. Despite that fact, however, they are often voiced in such a way as to give the impression that those who are uttering them had made some new and great discovery. They must not stand unchallenged, however, for they represent a perversion of the facts.

In the first place, it must be insisted that the picture offered by this objection is an oversimplification of the facts. It will not do to declare that until the time of the Reformation the church was accepted as an infallible authority, and then with the Reformation the Bible was presented as a substitute. A modern writer sets it forth thus:

> When the Reformation set the cat among the ecclesiastical pigeons, it was almost inevitable that the Bible should before long be given as spurious an eminence as the Church itself had enjoyed.[7]

It is true, of course, that through the long years of development the authority of the church was receiving ever greater and more prominent recognition. At the same time, the church claimed to reverence the Scriptures, and in her definition of doctrine did appeal to the Scriptures. The supreme authority of the Bible, however, was more and more pushed into the background. What the Reformation did was simply to clear the air and reestablish the Scriptures as the sole authority. One has but to read the writings of the New Testament in order to see that the church had begun with the belief that the Scriptures were that sole authority. Tradition, however, slowly but surely, began to usurp the place that at the beginning had belonged to the Bible. The Reformation swept away that tradition and once more called men to the Scriptures as the infallible authority. In other words, what the Reformation did was nothing more or less than to reestablish the rightful position of the Bible as the sole authority. The Reformation, in the providence of God, was a mighty purifying process. Gone was the error of human tradition and superstition which had grown during the Middle Ages, and in its place shone forth, once again, in all its purity, the infallible Word of God.

[7] William Neil, *The Rediscovery of the Bible* (London, 1954), 31.

In calling men back to the Bible, however, did the Reformers place the Bible in a position which belonged to Jesus Christ? Did they, in their endeavor to unite Protestantism against Rome, set up an authority other than Christ himself? Did they, in effect, supplant Christ with the Bible? Has the Bible, therefore, come between Christian faith and its Author? Has a false biblicism engulfed Protestantism? Strangely enough, through what we believe to be a misunderstanding of his teaching, Luther is sometimes omitted from the charge which we are now discussing. Be that as it may, we are told that the Reformers, at least Calvin and some of the others, were guilty of attributing to the Bible a position of priority which belonged to Christ alone.

How, we should like to ask, can the Bible possibly supplant the authority of Christ? We today would probably know nothing of Christ were it not for the Bible. Where do these modern theologians who claim to be zealous for the absolute authority of Christ receive their knowledge of Him? They receive it, humbling as the thought may be, from the *words* of the Bible. They do not receive it from some mysterious, nebulous Word which is to be separated from the actual words of Scripture. Much as modern theology may dislike the words of the Bible, it is from those despised words, and from them alone, that we learn of Jesus Christ. It would be well if that rather evident fact were kept in mind as we discuss this question.

What we are saying is so patent that there would seem to be no cause for discussion. Little children sing from the heart what the modern theologian seems unable to comprehend:

> Jesus loves me, this I know,
> For the Bible tells me so.

It is but a child's hymn, but it has a far more profound insight into the truth of the matter than has many a modern theologian who thinks that he can make a disjunction between Christ and his God-breathed Word. Were it not for the *words* of the Bible we would know nothing of the love of Jesus for lost sinners, nothing of his atoning death and his triumphant resurrection, nothing of the gift of his blessed Spirit, nothing of the promises of his sure return. Is it any wonder that children love to sing:

> Holy Bible, Book divine,
> Precious treasure, thou art mine:
> Mine to tell me whence I came;
> Mine to tell me what I am.

> Mine to chide me when I rove,
> Mine to show a Saviour's love,
> Mine thou art to guide and guard;
> Mine to punish or reward?

There may be some who will regard these words as expressing a mere bibliolatry. Those, however, who, because his Book has told them of him, know Jesus Christ, will dismiss all such cries as vain. Is this bibliolatry? Do Protestants worship a book? For our part we know of none who do. Protestants do not worship the paper and ink and the leather cover that goes to make up a Bible. It is true enough that the very form of the Word of God means a great deal to the true believer. Do we not all possess Bibles that have been with us throughout our lives? At home and abroad, they have been our constant companions, and a certain attachment, no doubt, is to be found in our hearts toward them. But our love for the Bible is something far deeper than the attachment one has toward an ancient and comfortable piece of furniture. We love this Book because of its message. Its very words are treasured in our hearts because we believe that these words were given by God himself. How deeply our love to God has grown when we could meditate during the early hours of the morning upon passages of the Scripture! We have repeated the words to ourselves over and over again, rejoicing in the blessing of the truth which they bring. Is this to dethrone Jesus Christ from his position of absolute authority? Those who speak thus evince little understanding of the true relationship between Jesus and his Word. It is through these blessed, divinely revealed *words* that our sinful hearts are brought closer to the Lord Jesus Christ.

The Reformers did not substitute the infallible Bible for an infallible Christ. By giving to the world an open Bible the Reformers preached Jesus Christ. When Calvin wrote his classic *Institutes,* he simply opened up the way for a serious and devout soul to come to a deeper knowledge of the Lord of Glory. And what about Luther; did he obscure Jesus Christ? When, after his vigorous stand at Worms, he was kidnapped and shut up in an old castle, what means did he employ to preach Jesus Christ as the absolute authority? If the modern theologians are correct, Luther did a very foolish thing. Thank God, however, that Luther did such a foolish thing. Luther translated the New Testament into the German language so that the people might hear the very words which Jesus Christ spoke. Luther knew nothing of this modern distinction between the Word of God and the words of the Bible. Luther, honest soul that he was, thought that the best way to get

Christ to the people was to give them the Bible in their own language. And since the people had this Word of God, they came to know Jesus Christ as their Lord and Savior. By giving his people the Bible, Luther thus gave them Jesus Christ.

We have a suspicion that those who are so concerned lest the Bible occupy a position which belongs to Christ have also themselves an "absolute" or "infallible" authority which they, whether they realize it or not, would themselves place upon the throne. It is the "infallible" mind of man. Not an infallible church, and not an infallible Bible, they tell us. Do they not, however, in their turn, demand an infallible "human mind" before which our Christianity must bow? Also, who is this Jesus Christ whose position has supposedly been dethroned by the Bible? We do not know him. Is he the eternal Son of God, the second person of the Holy Trinity, who, for our salvation, took unto himself human nature, without sin, being born of the Virgin Mary, to live upon this earth a sinless life, and, as our High Priest, to die upon the cross in our stead and to rise from the dead? Is that the Christ about whom the modern theologian is concerned? Has the position of this Christ been usurped by the Bible? We think not, for that blessed Christ is the one of whom the *words* of Holy Scripture speak. No, it is not that historic Christ which the Bible displaces, but some Christ whom we know not. There are many who say, "I am Christ." Is he for whom modern theologians seem so concerned one of these? If so, we know that he is at best but a fabrication of the human mind; he is not the divine Christ of Scripture. Is he but a name for worldly urbanity, for sentimental good cheer; is he but a slogan; is he the majority vote of the church council? We know him not, nor do we have any particular desire to know him. He cannot save us from our sins, sins which we have come to know through reading the words of the Scripture. Concerning all false Christs the Scriptures have said, ". . . see that ye be not troubled: for all *these things* must come to pass, but the end is not yet" (Matt. 24:6). Any Christ other than the historic Savior, the Christ of the Bible, is a Christ whom man has devised; and may we be spared from an "infallible" human mind which will tell us what Christ we are to worship.

The issue in the church today is not between those who maintain that the original manuscripts of the Bible were inerrant and those who believe that the original manuscripts may have contained errors, but who, nevertheless, are ardent believers in the doctrines of an evangelical, supernatural Christianity. If that ever were the situation in Christendom, it certainly is not so at the present day. It may have been that at one time there were

staunch believers in the other doctrines of Scripture who nevertheless held that the original copies of the Bible contained errors. If there were such, however, they have given way. Certainly there are few today who hold to such a position. The errors of the Bible which men now say they find are not minor at all. If they were only minor the situation would not be so desperate. The time has come, however, when men do not want to accept the biblical witness to itself, but rather would be guided by the dictates of human reason.

There is, consequently, a refusal to do justice to the biblical doctrine of inspiration. The real reason why men oppose the doctrine of an infallible Scripture is that they are not willing to embrace the biblical doctrine of inspiration. There is no such thing as inspiration which does not carry with it the correlate of infallibility. A Bible that is fallible—and we speak of course of the original—is a Bible that is not inspired. A Bible that is inspired is a Bible that is infallible. There is no middle ground. Many are the attempts, indeed, which have been made to discover such a middle ground. They are, however, vain. Futile indeed are the efforts of those who wish to hold to some doctrine of inspiration without at the same time accepting belief in infallibility. It soon becomes apparent that the type of inspiration to which they are cleaving is not one that is taught in Scripture itself.

In the city of Geneva, there is a monument to the Reformation, and on this monument are carved the figures of some of the great Reformers. Underneath their figures are inscribed the words *Post tenebras lux*—"After the darkness, light." It is a stirring inscription. After the darkness of the Middle Ages, when, to all intents and purposes at least, the Bible was a closed and chained Book, light came. And light came in a most strange manner. Light came when the pages of the Bible were once more opened and its truths preached and believed in the hearts of the people.

Today also darkness is covering the land and gross darkness the people. If light is to come, it will not be through the work of man but through the work of God's Holy Spirit. And light will come, we believe, when the Spirit once more causes the men of our day to turn from the superficiality of so much of modern religious life to the Word of the one living and true God. Then will the pages of the Bible once more be opened and men will turn to its life-giving words, for, being the words of God, they are "profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: that the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.

The Scripture Cannot Be Broken

Twentieth Century Writings on the Doctrine of Inerrancy

Edited by
John MacArthur

CROSSWAY